

The 2023-09-08 Al Haouz, Morocco earthquake (M_w 6.8,
us7000kufc):
a reproducible MTUQ + WISP validation study of a shallow
continental thrust

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MTUQ (point-source moment tensor) + WISP (kinematic finite fault); every parameter documented

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Abstract

We determine the point-source moment tensor (MTUQ) and a kinematic finite-fault model (WISP) of the 2023-09-08 22:11:01 UTC M_w 6.8 Al Haouz earthquake — a shallow (~ 26 km) oblique-reverse thrust in the Moroccan High Atlas that killed $\sim 2,900$ people. Unlike the mostly-unstudied events we analysed previously, this one has a USGS moment tensor and finite-fault model, so we use it to validate the pipeline and to document every data, frequency-band and processing parameter for reproducibility. Our double-couple moment tensor, 256/67/65 (M_w 6.95), lies 5.1° (Kagan angle) from the USGS W-phase solution; our WISP finite fault on the steep plane (peak slip 1.62 m, centroid ~ 25 km, $\sim 39 \times 38$ km; with the `shift_match` cross-correlation step applied) closely reproduces the USGS model (1.88 m, 25 km, 45×30 km) on the steep plane (though the teleseismic fit marginally, non-decisively, favours the shallow conjugate), and gives an ordinary stress drop of ~ 3 MPa. The study also yields a methodological result that mirrors our deep-event work: for a shallow source the joint body-plus-surface-wave inversion returns a confidently wrong (flipped, normal-faulting) mechanism, because surface waves are dip-slip-indeterminate at shallow depth (Kanamori & Given, 1981) and mismatched by 1-D dispersion; the body waves, through their depth phases, carry the correct dip-slip sense. Inverting body-only recovers the USGS mechanism.

Plain-language summary

A magnitude-6.8 earthquake struck the High Atlas mountains south of Marrakesh, on a reverse (compressional) fault about 26 km deep. Because this event is already well studied, we use it to check our analysis tools against the U.S. Geological Survey’s published answers — and they agree closely. Along the way we found a trap specific to shallow earthquakes: the long-period “surface waves” cannot tell which way such a fault slipped and gave the opposite (pull-apart) answer; the shorter-period “body waves” gave the correct (push-together) answer. This is the mirror image of what we learned for very deep earthquakes, where the body waves were the unreliable ones.

1 Event and USGS benchmarks

The earthquake (31.058°N , 8.385°W) is an intra-continental oblique-reverse rupture in the High Atlas. The USGS W-phase moment tensor is 122/29/132 (shallow SE-dipping) with conjugate 255/69/69

(steep NW-dipping), 94% double couple, centroid 30.5 km; the Mwc (26 km) and Mwb (24 km) solutions and the 19-km catalogue hypocentre span a genuine depth debate. The USGS finite-fault model adopted the steep plane (strike 251°, dip 69°), 45×30 km, peak slip 1.88 m, depth 25 km. These are the numbers we reproduce.

2 Data and parameters (documented for reproducibility)

Determinism. FDSN data fetching is deterministic in its parameters but not across time (data-centre availability changes; transient request failures drop stations). The reproducible unit is therefore the archived waveforms plus the parameters below: re-running from the saved SAC files is byte-deterministic, while re-fetching yields a near-identical set. The inversions are deterministic (MTUQ is an exhaustive grid search; WISP’s annealing reproduces to four decimals). Compute is CPU-only (no GPU): MTUQ parallelises with MPI (`mpirun -n 20`); WISP uses OpenMP (Green’s functions and annealing) plus a `multiprocessing` pool for data processing.

item	value
WISP data	<code>ffm manage acquire -t body</code> (II, G, IU, GE), ~150 broadband stations
MTUQ data	20 GSN broadband, 31–86°, reused from the WISP fetch; response via StationXML inventory (output DISP), rotated ZNE→RT
MTUQ body band	15–40 s (<code>--bwband 15,40,80,8</code>); 80-s window, ±8 s shifts
MTUQ surface band	50–100 s (shown to flip the shallow mechanism; excluded from the solution)
MTUQ Green’s functions	syngine ak135 (<code>ak135f_2s</code>)
MTUQ grid	DoubleCoupleGridRegular, 40 pts/axis (~64k orientations × 5 magnitudes)
WISP body filter	0.006–1.0 Hz, wavelet scales 2–8
WISP surface waves	used (shallow source; above the 125-km surface-wave GF cap)
adopted depth	26 km

MTUQ teleseismic stations (20; azimuthal-equidistant, rings 30/60/90 deg)

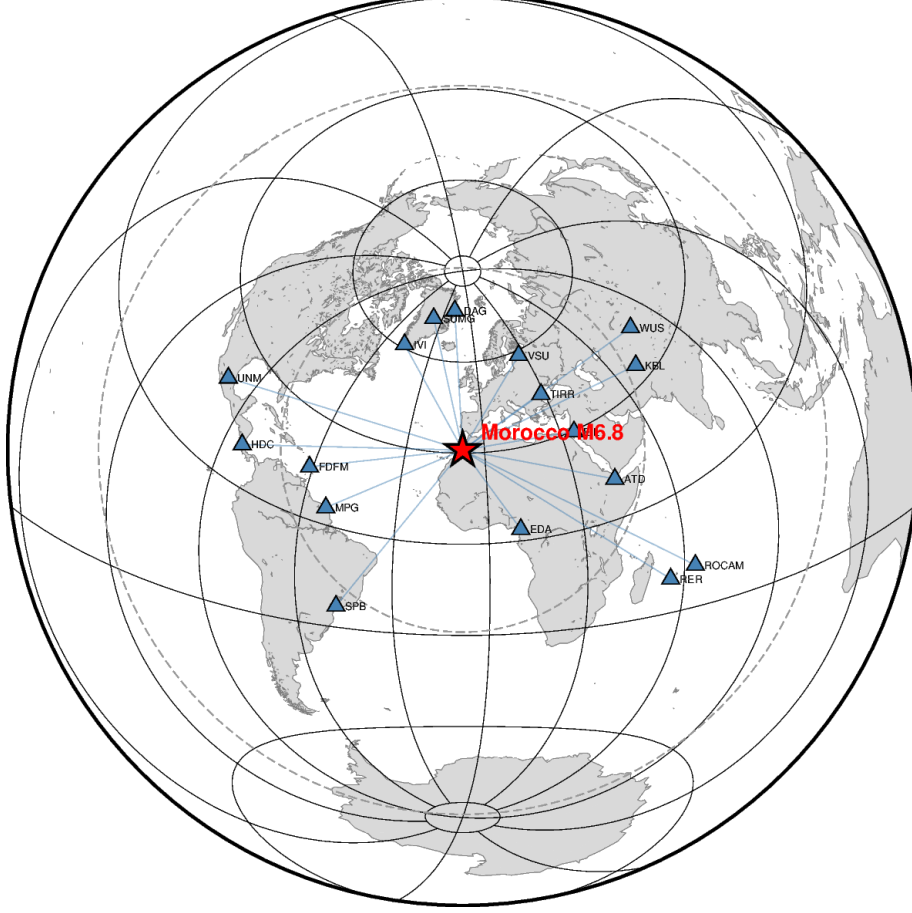


Figure 1: The 20 GSN teleseismic broadband stations used for the moment tensor, on an azimuthal-equidistant projection centred on the epicentre (rings at 30/60/90°).

3 Moment tensor: the shallow-event trap and cure

Run jointly (body 10–33 s + surface 50–100 s), the DC search converges confidently on a flipped, normal-faulting mechanism $\sim 89^\circ$ (Kagan) from USGS. The cause is physical: at shallow depth the vertical dip-slip moment-tensor elements (M_{rt} , M_{rp}) are weakly excited at long period — the Kanamori–Given shallow indeterminacy — and the surface waves are additionally mismatched by 1-D dispersion (large time shifts, poor amplitude fit), so they cannot fix, and actively mislead, the dip-slip sense. The body waves, through their depth phases, resolve it. We therefore invert body-only (a `--onlybody` option added to the runners). This is the mirror image of the deep-event rule, where short-period body waves fail and the surface/long-period waves are reliable.

solution	M_w	strike/dip/rake	Kagan vs USGS M_w	%DC
DC (adopted)	6.95	256/67/65	5.1°	—
full moment tensor	6.80	270/63/63	19.1°	66% (USGS 94%)

Table 1: Body-only MTUQ. The DC solution matches USGS to 5.1°; the full MT is destabilised by the same shallow-source indeterminacy (spurious non-DC, 66% vs 94%), which is exactly why the DC constraint is standard for shallow sources. We adopt the DC solution.

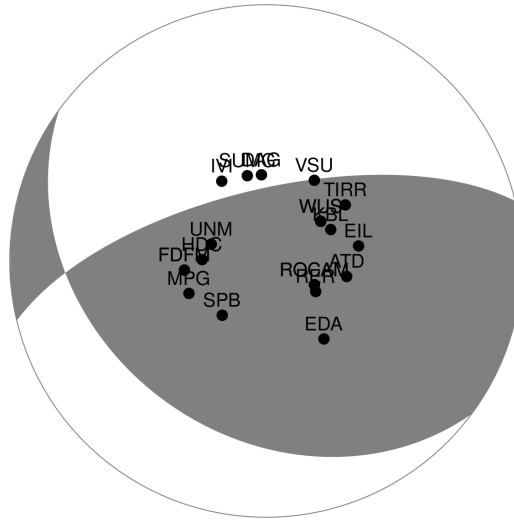


Figure 2: Adopted DC moment tensor (256/67/65) with the teleseismic station distribution — the correct oblique-reverse thrust.



2023-09-08T22:11:01 31.06°N 8.38°W M_W 6.95 Depth 26.0 km
 model: ak135f_2s solver: syngine misfit (L2): 5.734e-01
 body waves: 15.0 - 40.0 s (80.0 s), surface waves: 50.0 - 100.0 s (300.0 s)
 strike dip slip: 256 67 65, lune coords γ δ : 0 0, N-Np-Ns: 20-20-20



Figure 3: Body-wave fits of the adopted DC solution (black observed, red synthetic).



2023-09-08T22:11:01 31.06°N 8.38°W M_W 6.80 Depth 26.0 km
 model: ak135f_2s solver: syngine misfit (L2): 5.358e-01
 body waves: 15.0 - 40.0 s (80.0 s), surface waves: 50.0 - 100.0 s (300.0 s)
 strike dip slip: 270 63 63, lune coords γ δ : -9 16, N-Np-Ns: 20-20-20

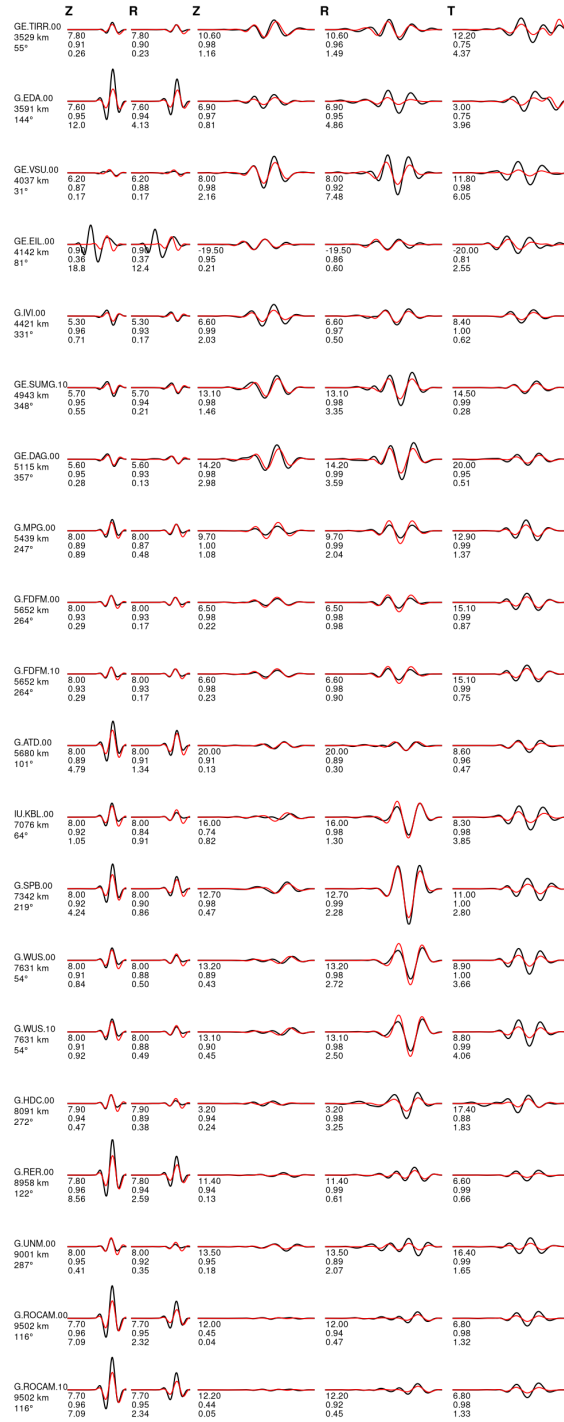


Figure 4: Body-wave fits of the full moment tensor (270/63/63, 66% DC), shown for completeness; the adopted solution is the better-constrained DC.

4 Depth

The catalogue (19 km), Mwc (26 km), USGS finite fault (25 km) and Mww centroid (30.5 km) disagree. A joint depth search is unreliable here (the surface-wave flip contaminates it), so we run a body-only DC+depth search: its global misfit minimum is at ~ 33 km (a broad 30–34 km trough), independently supporting the deeper centroid (~ 30 –33 km, matching the USGS Mww 30.5 km) over the 19-km catalogue hypocentre, with a weaker secondary minimum near 10–14 km from the depth-phase trade-off. The WISP slip (below) spreads over 17–37 km, consistent with this mid-to-deep-crustal centroid.

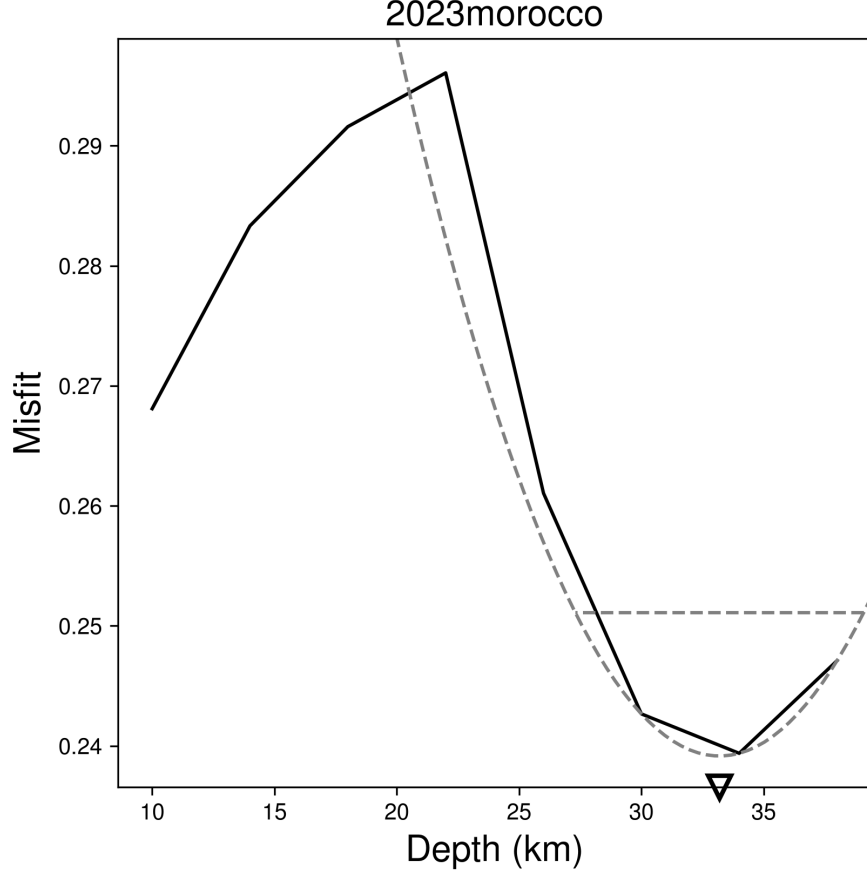


Figure 5: Body-only misfit versus source depth (best ~ 33 km).

5 Finite fault: validation against the USGS model

We ran WISP `auto_model` on both nodal planes of our own MTUQ mechanism (internal consistency: the fault planes come from our moment tensor, not an external CMT). Being shallow, surface waves are fully used, together with teleseismic P (35 channels) and SH (26 channels) body waves. The adopted models apply the cross-correlation time-shift step (`shift_match`; see below), which every other event in this study used but the first Morocco pass had skipped.

plane	misfit (pre $\rightarrow$ post shift)	peak slip	$L \times W$	USGS finite fault
NP1 = steep 256/67 (= USGS FF plane)	0.1402 $\rightarrow$ 0.1235	1.50 $\rightarrow$ 1.62 m	39 $\times$ 38 km	251/69, 1.88 m, 25 km
NP2 = shallow 126/33 (WISP-preferred)	0.1376 $\rightarrow$ 0.1196	1.46 $\rightarrow$ 1.71 m	43 $\times$ 38 km	—

Table 2: Plane discrimination is an honest ambiguity: after the shift WISP’s teleseismic fit still marginally prefers the shallow plane (0.1196 vs 0.1235, $\sim 3\%$), disagreeing with USGS’s finite-fault steep-plane choice — the shift does not flip the preference. As for the Chile events, teleseismic fit is a weak plane discriminant; USGS’s steep choice rests on aftershocks and InSAR. We show the steep plane (NP1, = the USGS finite-fault plane) for validation.

The cross-correlation time-shift step

WISP provides `shift_match2` (auto cross-correlation, ± 5 s body / ± 12 s surface) and `manual_shift` (user-entered per-station) to remove the residual timing mismatch left by a 1-D velocity model and centroid mislocation. Each sets a trace’s alignment index once and holds it fixed during the annealing (it is not a free inversion parameter). Applied here as auto cross-correlation for body (P+SH) and surface (Rayleigh+Love), then re-inverting, it cuts the misfit $\sim 12\text{--}13\%$ on both planes and visibly aligns the SH peaks (TLY, YAK, KBS, PALK) while leaving M_w unchanged and merely sharpening the slip.

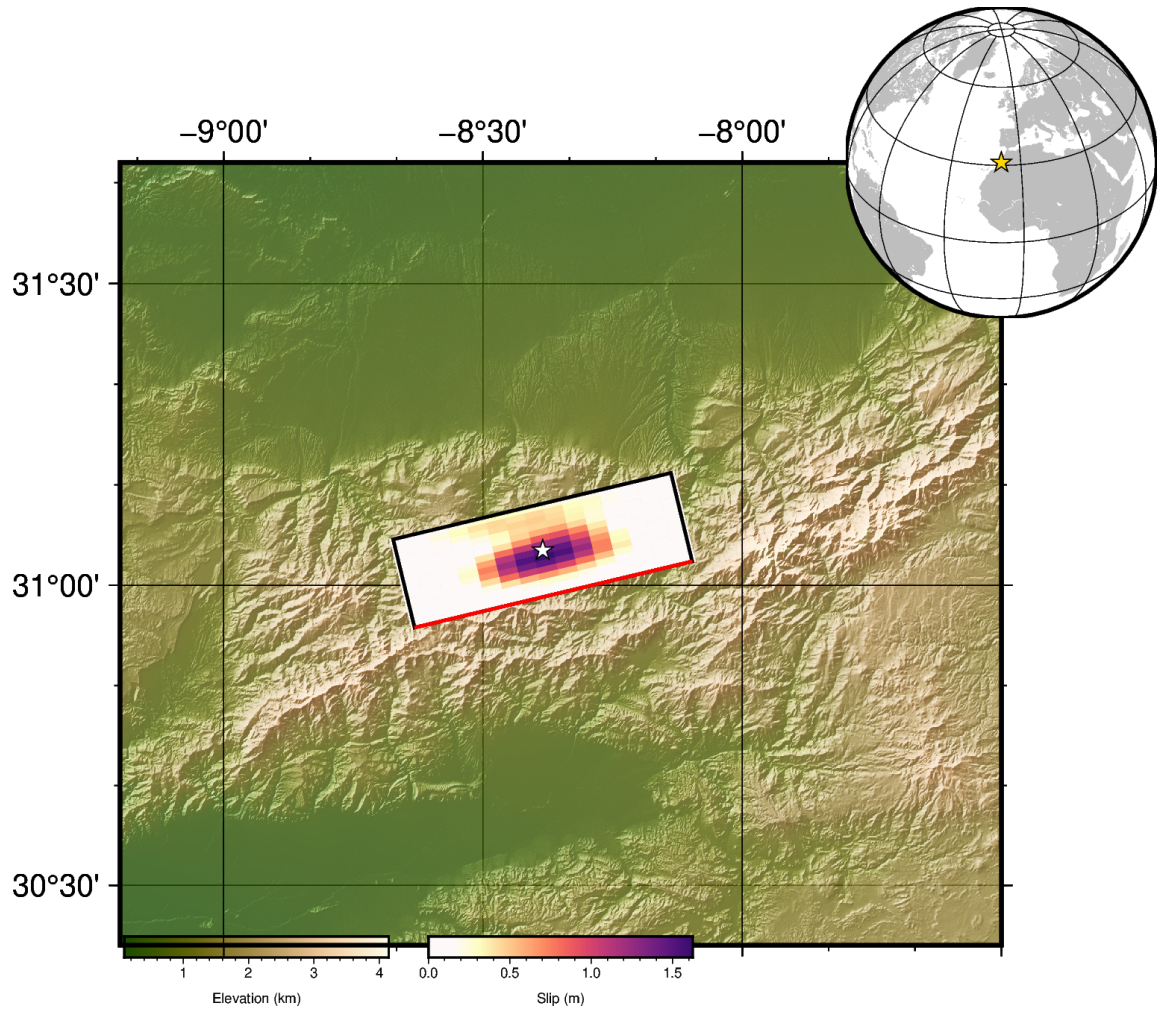


Figure 6: Map view of the preferred (steep-plane) slip model: fault slip projected to the surface, with the epicentre (star) and coastlines. WISP PlotMap.

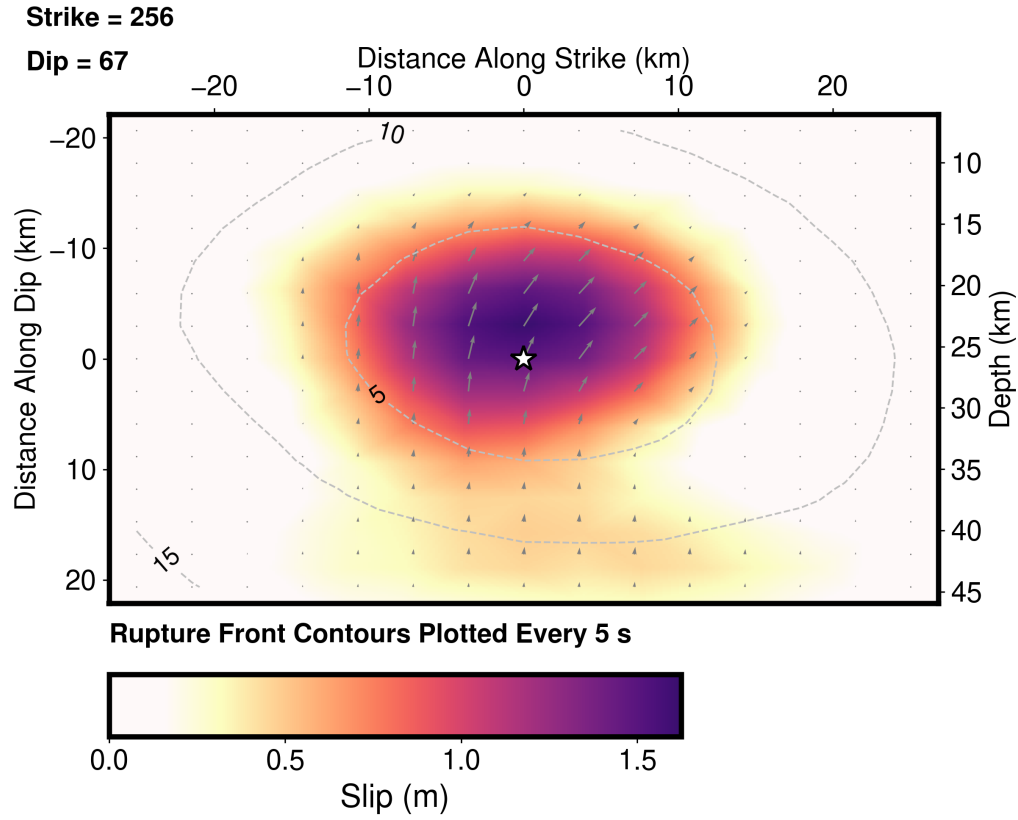


Figure 7: On-fault slip model (steep plane, with time shift). Star: hypocentre; contours: rupture front every 5 s; arrows: slip direction (reverse). Peak 1.62 m, centroid ~ 25 km depth.

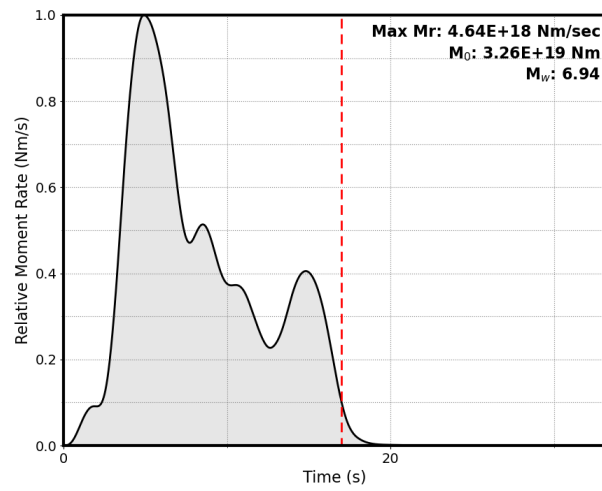


Figure 8: Moment-rate function (steep plane).

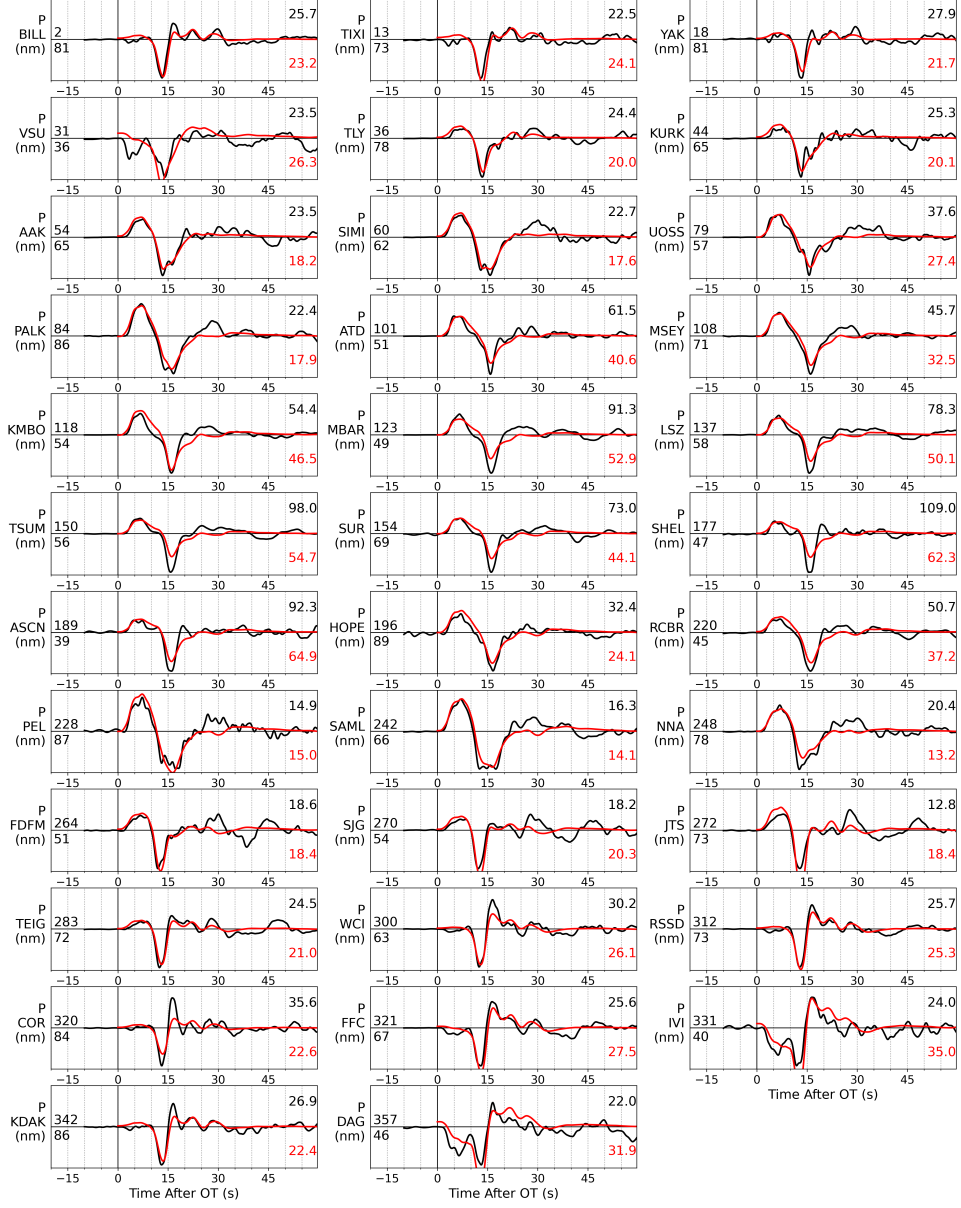


Figure 9: WISP P-wave fits (steep plane, with time shift).

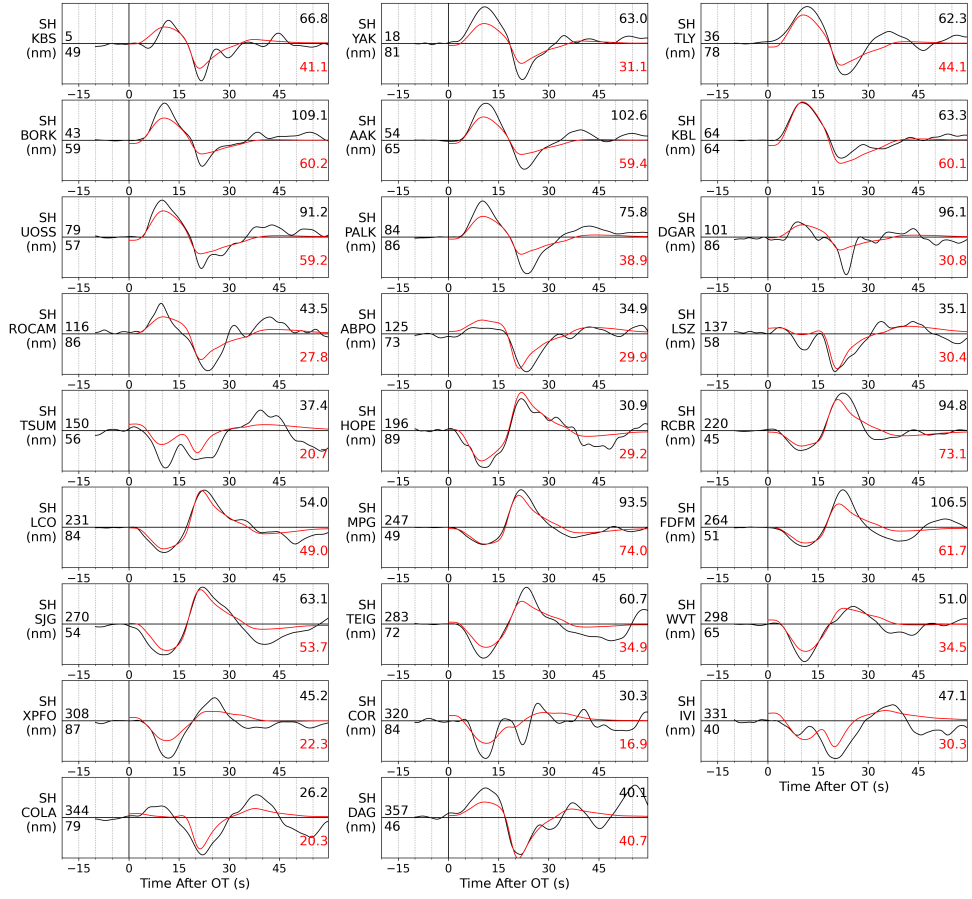


Figure 10: WISP SH-wave fits (steep plane, with time shift): teleseismic SH (transverse, 26 channels) alongside the 35 P channels. Compared to the un-shifted run, the synthetic peaks now align with the observed at TLY, YAK, KBS and PALK.

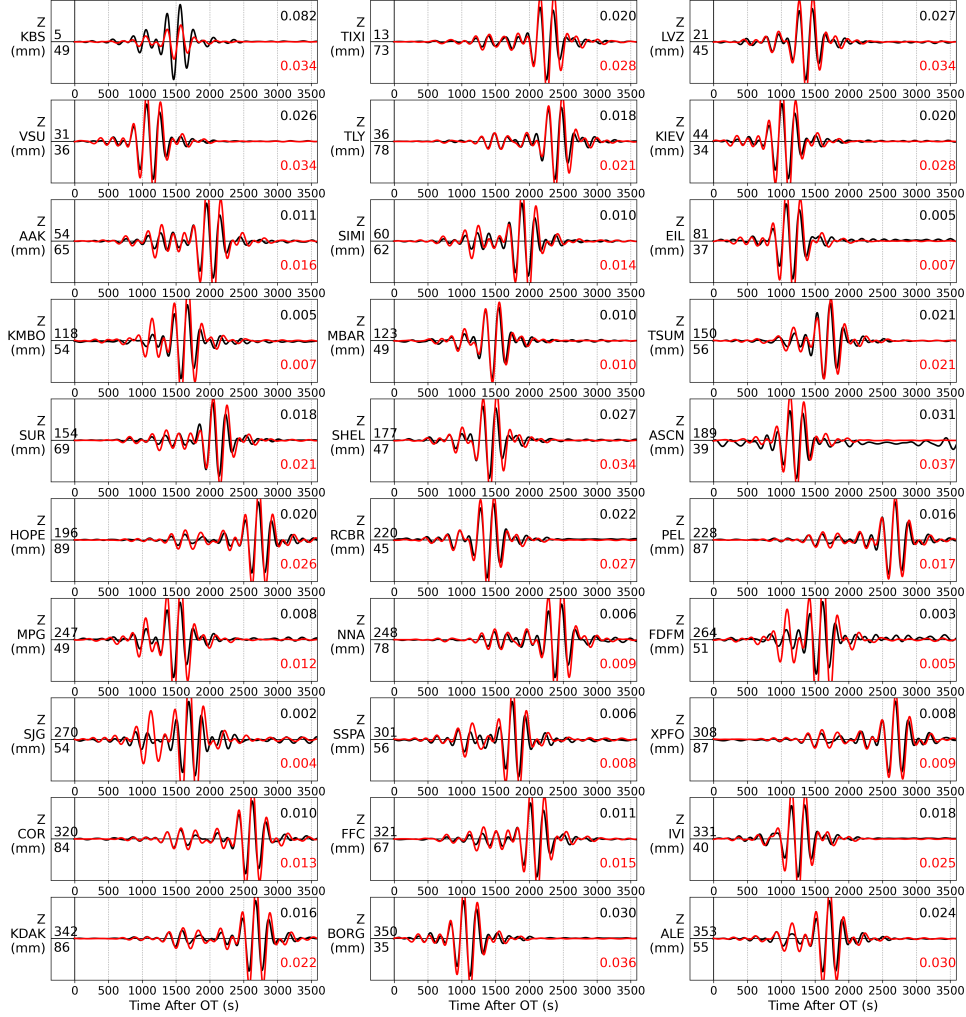


Figure 11: WISP Rayleigh-wave fits (steep plane).

Stress drop and moment magnitude

From the shifted slip distribution (Eshelby circular crack $\Delta\sigma = \frac{7}{16}M_0/R^3$, effective area from the slip participation ratio), the stress drop is 3.15 MPa (steep) / 3.26 MPa (shallow) — ~ 3 MPa, an ordinary value for a continental crustal reverse earthquake (global median ~ 3 –4 MPa), independent of the plane. Both the MT and the finite fault give $M_w \approx 6.94$, i.e. ~ 0.15 units ($\times 1.6$ in moment) above the USGS M_{ww} 6.8; the W-phase M_{ww} is the more authoritative long-period moment, and

our body-wave-driven estimate runs higher. Since $\Delta\sigma \propto M_0$, normalising to M_{ww} would lower the stress drop to ~ 2 MPa, so the defensible statement is $\sim 2\text{--}3$ MPa, ordinary.

6 Summary

1. The pipeline reproduces the USGS moment tensor to 5.1° and the USGS finite-fault model (slip amplitude, depth, dimensions, preferred plane) for this well-studied event — a clean end-to-end validation across a new tectonic regime (shallow continental thrust).
2. Shallow-event rule: invert body waves for the mechanism; surface waves are dip-slip-indeterminate at shallow depth and flip the solution. Mirror of the deep-event rule.
3. Use the DC constraint for shallow sources — the full MT is destabilised by the same indeterminacy (66% vs USGS 94% DC).
4. Apply the **shift_match** cross-correlation step (as every other event did): it cut the WISP misfit $\sim 12\text{--}13\%$, aligned the SH peaks, and sharpened the slip without changing M_w . Stress drop ~ 3 MPa (ordinary); M_w 6.94, ~ 0.15 above the USGS M_{ww} 6.8.
5. Every parameter is tabulated; the analysis re-runs deterministically from the archived waveforms. Pipeline is CPU-parallel (MPI + OpenMP), no GPU.